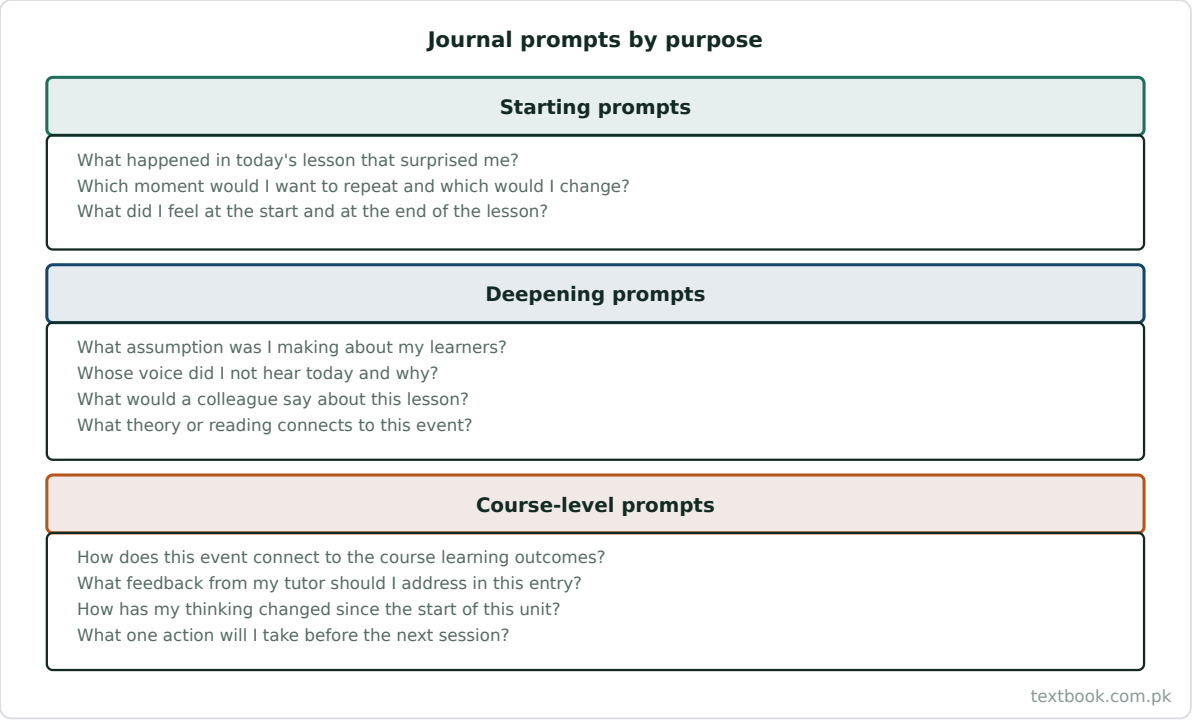
Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 6.4 - Prompts, and drawing the course together

A real classroom situation

Mr Aslam has been asked to start a reflective journal. He sits down on Friday evening with his notebook open. He stares at the page. "What am I supposed to write?" he thinks. "Nothing dramatic happened this week. The lessons were normal." He closes the notebook and decides to try again next week.



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Mr Aslam's problem is the most common one in journal writing: not having a way in. This topic's first half gives you a set of prompts that

> work when nothing dramatic has happened, because most teaching weeks are not dramatic, and the journal has to work in ordinary weeks as well as extraordinary ones.
>
> The topic's second half does something different. It draws the course together. The guide's final bullet is "Concluding the course", and this is where it happens: the place where the logic of Units 1 to 3 and the practice of Units 4 to 6 are shown to be one course, not two.

Explanation

Prompts for starting an entry

When nothing dramatic has happened, start with one of these:

- **What surprised me this week?** Not what went wrong - what was different from what I expected. A pupil who usually struggles and did well. A technique that usually works and did not. Surprise is the beginning of reflection because it signals that an expectation was violated.
- **What did I assume this week that turned out to be wrong?** Assumptions are everywhere in teaching. "They have done the homework." "They understood because they were quiet." "That method works with this class." Finding one assumption that failed is a complete journal entry.
- **What would I do differently if I could re-teach one moment?** Pick one moment, not the whole lesson. The smaller the moment, the easier the analysis.
- **What did a pupil do or say that I did not expect?** Pupils are a source of data you cannot get any other way. Their unexpected responses tell you what your teaching actually produced, not what you intended.

Prompts for deepening an entry

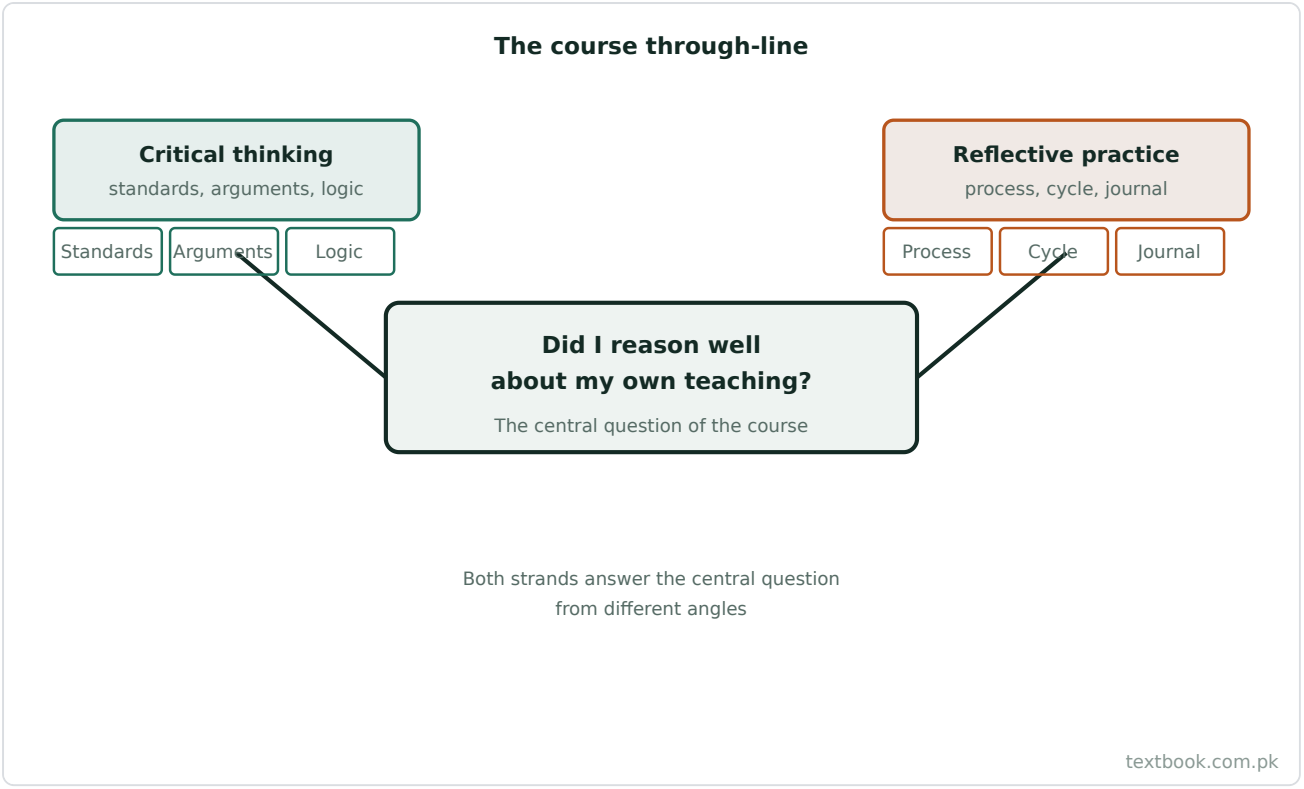
When you have a first draft and it feels flat, deepen it with one of these:

- **What evidence supports what I am saying?** If I claim the pupils did not understand, what exactly did they do or fail to do that shows it? Turn the claim into an evidence-based finding.
- **What would a colleague say if they watched this lesson?** Brookfield's colleague lens. A colleague would notice things you did not: who you called on, who you ignored, how long you waited.
- **What would a pupil say about this lesson?** Brookfield's student lens. Pupils experience your teaching differently from the way you experience it. A quiet lesson for you may have been a confusing one for them.
- **What am I taking for granted here?** Every entry rests on assumptions. Name one and test it.

Course-level prompts

These draw on the whole course, not just one lesson:

- **Where did I apply a Unit 1 standard this week?** Clarity, accuracy, relevance, depth. Did you evaluate a piece of reasoning - someone else's or your own - against a standard?
- **Where did I skip a stage of the reflective cycle?** Unit 5's cycle has five stages. Most teachers skip the analysis stage. Did you?
- **Where did my Unit 3 training in argument show up?** Did you classify an argument as deductive or inductive? Did you catch yourself judging one kind by the wrong test?
- **What assumption of mine was challenged this week, and by what?** This is Brookfield's question, and it is the one that produces the deepest entries.



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Drawing the course together

This course has two halves. Units 1 to 3 are a logic course: standards, arguments, premises and conclusions, deductive and inductive patterns, validity and strength. Units 4 to 6 are a practice course: reflective thinking, the process, the cycle, the models, the journal. A trainee who treats them as separate will keep the logic in the examination hall and never bring it to their classroom.

The course is designed so that the two halves meet in the journal. A reflective journal entry is where you reason about your own teaching - and reasoning is what Units 1 to 3 taught you to do. The standards (Unit 1) are what you apply to your own analysis. The argument-identification skill (Unit 2) is what you use to find the reasoning inside your own decisions. The validity/strength distinction (Unit 3) is what keeps you from accepting a weak explanation of your own teaching just because it feels plausible.

Brookfield (2017) puts it directly: reflection that is not informed by critical-thinking standards becomes self-justification. A teacher who writes "the

lesson failed because the pupils were weak" has made a claim. A teacher who asks "what evidence shows it was the pupils' weakness rather than my explanation?" has applied a standard. The first is a diary. The second is a journal. Units 1 to 3 are what make the second possible.

This is why the reflection file is assessed in this course and not in a purely method course. A method course teaches you *how* to teach. This course teaches you *how to examine your teaching*, and examination requires the tools Units 1 to 3 gave you.

Activity: Use the prompts

Work in pairs. About 20 minutes.

Each pair chooses one of the starting prompts above and uses it to write a short journal entry (5-8 sentences) about a real or imagined teaching week. Then choose one of the deepening prompts and rewrite the entry at a deeper level.

Then, individually, write one sentence answering the course-level prompt: "Where did my Unit 1-3 training show up this week?" Share with your partner.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name two starting prompts and two deepening prompts for journal writing.

2. **Understand** In two or three sentences, explain why "nothing dramatic happened" is not a reason to skip a journal entry.

3. **Apply** A trainee writes, "The lesson was fine. Nothing went wrong." Use a starting prompt to turn that into the beginning of a journal entry.

4. **Understand** In two sentences, explain how the logic of Units 1 to 3 and the practice of Units 4 to 6 meet in the journal.

Summary

A journal needs a way in when nothing dramatic has happened: use prompts that ask what surprised you, what you assumed, what you would do differently, what a pupil did that you did not expect. Deepen entries with prompts that ask for evidence, a colleague's view, a pupil's view or an assumption you have not tested. The course's two halves meet in the journal: Units 1 to 3 taught you to reason; Units 4 to 6 taught you to reflect; the journal is where you reason about your own teaching, and the standards from Unit 1 are what keep it from becoming self-justification.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can name two starting prompts and two deepening prompts.
- [ ] I can use a starting prompt to begin an entry when nothing dramatic happened.
- [ ] I can explain how the logic and practice halves of the course meet in the journal.

- [ ] I can write a course-level journal entry that draws on Units 1 to 3 and Units 4 to 6.

Try this at your practicum school

Write one journal entry this week using a starting prompt. Then add a second paragraph using a deepening prompt. Finally, add one sentence answering a course-level prompt. Bring all three to your tutorial and be ready to say which was the hardest to write and why.

Summative task

Write 250 to 300 words that (a) uses one of the course-level prompts above to produce a journal entry that draws on at least one idea from Units 1 to 3 and one from Units 4 to 6, (b) names which reflective model or level your entry reaches, and (c) explains in one paragraph how the course's logic half and practice half are connected in your entry.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	Levels
Course-level entry	0-3: draws on at least one idea from Units 1-3 (standards, argument, validity/strength) and one from Units 4-6 (process, cycle, model) with a genuine connection / draws on one half only / neither.
Model or level named	0-2: names the model or level with evidence from the entry / a vague reference / none.

Criterion	Levels
Connection explained	0-3: explains how the logic and practice halves meet in the entry, tied to the specific content (**Analyze*: the explanation turns on the specific ideas used, not on general statements about the course) / a general explanation / none.
Clarity	0-2: within the word band and organised under the three parts / unclear or over length.

Further reading

Brookfield, S. D. (2017). *Becoming a critically reflective teacher* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass. Chapter 7 discusses how critical-thinking standards inform reflective practice.

Taggart, G. L., & Wilson, A. P. (2005). *Promoting reflective thinking in teachers: 50 action strategies* (2nd ed.). Corwin Press. Chapter 5 provides a bank of reflective prompts.

Was this page helpful? Yes

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback